Difference Between Bribe and Gift

Cost, Time, and Intention

Introduction

In engineering practice, engineers often deal with clients, suppliers, vendors, and contractors. Sometimes they may receive small gifts, meals, invitations, or favors. The ethical problem is that a simple gift can sometimes become a **bribe**.

According to Fleddermann, the acceptance of gifts is a gray area because gifts may become bribes or may be seen as bribes. He explains that the difference may depend on the **value of the gift**, but it always depends on the **intention behind the gift**.

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1. Meaning of Gift

A **gift** is a small item or gesture given as a sign of respect, goodwill, or professional relationship. It is not meant to force or influence someone's decision.

For example, a company pen, calendar, diary, or coffee mug with the company logo is usually acceptable because it has low value and is mainly used for advertising. Fleddermann says gifts of nominal value, such as mugs or calendars, are generally not a problem.

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2. Meaning of Bribe

A **bribe** is money, gift, favor, or benefit given to a person in a position of trust to influence them to act dishonestly.

For example, if a supplier gives an engineer expensive tickets or money so that the engineer selects their product, it is a bribe. Fleddermann defines a bribe as something offered or given to influence or persuade someone to act dishonestly.

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3. Difference Based on Cost

Cost is an important sign. A low-cost gift is usually acceptable if it does not affect professional judgment.

A high-cost gift creates doubt because it may influence the engineer’s decision. For example, a Rs. 200 pen may be acceptable, but an expensive watch, hotel stay, or luxury dinner from a supplier may look like a bribe.

Fleddermann gives the example that a five-dollar coffee mug may be acceptable, but a very expensive crystal bowl creates an ethical question.

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4. Difference Based on Time

Timing also matters. A gift given during normal professional interaction may be acceptable if it is small and open.

But if a gift is given just before contract approval, tender selection, inspection, or result submission, it becomes suspicious. At that time, the giver may be trying to influence the engineer’s decision.

For example, a supplier giving a small calendar at a conference is different from giving an expensive dinner one day before the engineer selects a vendor.

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5. Difference Based on Intention

Intention is the most important factor. A gift is acceptable only when it is given without expecting unfair benefit.

If the purpose is to influence judgment, get a contract, hide a defect, pass an inspection, or receive special treatment, then it becomes a bribe. Fleddermann clearly says that the distinction between gift and bribe **always** depends on the intent of the gift.

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6. Why Bribery Is Unethical

Bribery is unethical because it destroys fairness and honesty. It gives advantage to the person who can pay more, not to the person who provides the best product or service.

Fleddermann explains that bribery corrupts the free-market system, is anti-competitive, favors the rich, and treats people like things that can be bought and sold.

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7. How Engineers Should Avoid Bribery

Engineers should first follow company policy. If the company does not allow gifts, then even small gifts should be refused.

If there is no clear rule, the engineer should ask for approval from management. Fleddermann also gives the **New York Times Test**: if the engineer would feel embarrassed seeing the gift reported publicly in a newspaper, then the gift should not be accepted.

Conclusion

A gift and a bribe may look similar, but they are ethically different. A gift is small, open, and given with goodwill. A bribe is given to influence judgment or gain unfair benefit.

Engineers should judge the situation through **cost, time, and intention**. If the gift is expensive, given near an important decision, or meant to influence professional judgment, it should be refused.

Quick Difference Table

Basis	Gift	Bribe
Cost	Low cost, symbolic	Expensive or valuable
Time	Normal occasion	Before decision/approval
Intention	Goodwill/respect	Influence or unfair benefit
Effect	No effect on judgment	Affects professional judgment
Ethical Status	Usually acceptable	Always unethical

How to Apply in Case Studies

In a case study, check three things:

Cost: Is the item small or expensive?
Time: Was it given near a contract, tender, inspection, or approval?
Intention: Was it given for goodwill or to influence the engineer?

Then write the final decision. If the gift can affect judgment or create the appearance of dishonesty, the engineer should refuse it or report it according to company policy.

5-Mark Exam Answer

A gift is a small item or favor given as a sign of goodwill, respect, or professional relationship. A bribe is money, gift, favor, or benefit given to a person in a position of trust to influence them to act dishonestly. According to Fleddermann, the difference between a gift and a bribe may depend on the value of the gift, but it always depends on the intention behind it.

The first difference is cost. Low-cost items such as pens, calendars, or mugs are usually acceptable, but expensive gifts such as watches, trips, or luxury dinners create ethical doubt. The second difference is time. A gift given during a normal meeting may be acceptable, but a gift given just before contract approval, inspection, or tender selection becomes suspicious. The third and most important difference is intention. If the purpose is goodwill, it may be a gift. If the purpose is to influence judgment, get unfair benefit, or hide wrongdoing, it is a bribe.

Therefore, engineers should avoid expensive gifts, gifts given at suspicious times, and gifts that may affect professional judgment. They should follow company policy and refuse anything that creates conflict of interest or appearance of dishonesty.